



GCC Entry Blueprint

Phase-1 | Pre-Engagement | No-Cost (Directional)

UGCC Master Franchise & Area Developer Introduction Plan (UAE & KSA)

Directional blueprint to align on: Market Fit | Partner Readiness | Candidate Sourcing Funnel | 120-Day Activation

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About this document

This document explains how we see Dessert39's opportunity in the Gulf, who we believe your best partners would be, and how we'd help you reach a signed Master Franchise or Area Developer agreement in the next four months.

Two short notes before we start.

- This is a working plan, not a legal opinion. When the partnership progresses, your lawyers and our local advisors will work through contracts, halal certificates, and government registrations together.
- We've kept things at a high level on purpose. Once we move forward formally, we get into named partner shortlists, contract negotiation support, and the specific paperwork.

What's in this document

- Why the Gulf is a good fit for Dessert39, and why now
- What's already strong, and what we'd need to fix, before meeting partners
- The kinds of partners we'd approach
- How we'd run the introductions – the four-month plan, week by week
- How we'd report progress to your team in Seoul

What we'd deliver if we work together

- A real shortlist of named partners we believe Dessert39 should meet
- Confidentiality agreements signed with each one before your name is shared
- Setup and support for the first calls between Seoul and the partners
- Help adapting the franchise package for the Gulf – halal pathway, Arabic brand work, store-economics in local terms
- Support all the way through to a signed Master Franchise or Area Developer agreement

1. The opportunity

1.1. Why the Gulf, and why now

The Gulf is one of the best markets in the world for what Dessert39 does. Here's why.

Diabetes is widespread.

Around 17% of adults in the UAE and 18% in Saudi Arabia live with diabetes – among the highest rates in the world. Many more are pre-diabetic or actively managing their weight. Dessert39's whole story – desserts you can enjoy without sugar regret – speaks directly to this group, and almost no imported dessert brand has owned this space.

Wellness is a national priority in both countries.

The UAE has a national strategy called Wellbeing 2031. Saudi Arabia has the Quality of Life Program inside Vision 2030. Brands that align with these national health goals get a softer landing – easier conversations with malls, faster acceptance from consumers, and goodwill from authorities.

Korean lifestyle brands have a real tailwind here.

Saudi Arabia has invested heavily in Korean content over the last few years. K-pop, K-dramas, and K-beauty all sell well across the Gulf. Dessert39 walks into that affection ready-made – you don't have to teach the market who Korean brands are.

Your operating model is a gift to operators.

The cold-chain frozen system, the 12-month preservation, the no-pastry-chef-required setup – these are exactly the things F&B operators in the Gulf love. Labor is expensive here, and skilled pastry talent is hard to find. The economics work for store partners in a way most café concepts don't.

You can sell more than just café formats.

Cafés, kiosks, mall stands, retail SKUs in supermarkets – all are addressable in the Gulf. That widens the kind of partner who can work with you.

1.2. How we'd recommend entering

Split the Gulf into two markets and move on both in parallel – UAE first for speed, Saudi Arabia for scale.

UAE - faster, simpler, opens the door.

Decisions happen quickly. English works fine in business settings. Premium retail locations in Dubai and Abu Dhabi are accessible. You can have your first stores opening in the UAE while Saudi paperwork is still moving – and those UAE stores become the proof that helps you open Saudi conversations.

Saudi Arabia – bigger market, longer cycle, much higher ceiling.

The Saudi market is larger and the upside from Vision 2030 megaprojects (NEOM, Diriyah, Red Sea, Qiddiya) is significant. But Saudi requires more formal steps: a franchise registration with the Ministry of Investment, mandatory halal certification, and Arabic-first communication. Saudi Founding Day (22 February) and Saudi National Day (23 September) are good launch windows for a new brand.

Two partners, not one.

We'd recommend giving the UAE to one Master Franchise partner and Saudi Arabia to a separate Area Developer – rather than handing the whole Gulf to a single operator. Two reasons. First, less risk if one partner doesn't perform. Second, each market gets a partner specifically suited to it.

1.3. What's ready, what needs work, and what we have to build

Three areas to think about. We mark each one green, yellow, or red – meaning ready, mostly there with some work needed, or has to be built from scratch.

Your franchise package – ● yellow

Your brand and product are ready to export. But the franchise document you give partners is built for Korea. Before serious meetings in the Gulf, we'd adapt it – halal pathway, Arabic identity, and a store-economics model that uses Gulf rents and salaries.

Your regulatory pathway – ● yellow

The market wants what you sell. But you'll need a clear answer when partners ask "how do we get this approved?" – what halal certification, what food-safety registration, what franchise registration. We'd put that answer together for both markets.

Your partner pipeline – ● red

There are no qualified partners in conversations yet. This is the engine we'd build for you. It's the heart of this engagement.

1.4. How Dessert39 wins here

Four ways to win, working together:

The healthy-dessert wedge.

You'd be the first credible imported dessert brand making this claim. As long as the claims stay disciplined and the halal credentials are solid, this is a strong differentiator that no competitor can copy quickly.

Store economics.

Lower running costs because partners don't need pastry chefs. Faster ROI because the central kitchen does the hard work. This matters to every operator we'd talk to.

The Korean halo.

Gen-Z and Millennials in the Gulf already love Korean brands. You don't have to teach the market who you are.

Multiple formats.

Cafés, kiosks, retail SKUs. Operators can start small or go big. That widens the pool of people who can work with you.

1.5. What we'd want closed before meeting partners

- Adapt the franchise package for the Gulf – especially store economics in local terms (Gulf rents, salaries, expected returns)
- Put together a halal certification plan, recipe by recipe (gelatine sources, alcohol traces in flavourings, sweeteners)
- Adapt the brand for Arabic – logo lockup, menu, signage, packaging
- Define the kind of partner we're looking for, and the criteria they have to pass

1.6. The four-month plan, in plain language

Month 1 - Get your house in order.

Adapt the franchise package, document the regulatory plan for both markets, and build the first list of potential partners.

Month 2 - Reach out, quietly, partner by partner.

Sign confidentiality agreements with the operators who respond. Once signed, share your name and the full story.

Month 3 - Narrow it down.

Get the strongest candidates onto calls with your team in Seoul. Begin drafting the first MOU with the strongest UAE candidate.

Month 4 - Get to face-to-face.

Strongest candidates meet your team in person – Seoul or in the Gulf. Finalize the UAE MOU. Plan the next six months.

1.7. What we need from you to get going

- A decision on where to start: UAE first, Saudi first, or both at the same time. Our recommendation: both.
- A decision on whether to give the whole Gulf to one partner, or split it. Our recommendation: split – one partner in the UAE, one in Saudi.
- The terms you're comfortable with: territory, exclusivity, length of agreement, how many stores per year.
- Your current franchise package – even if it's only the Korean version. We adapt it from there.
- A note on which recipes are already halal-certified, and which need work.
- Confirmation to start the engagement formally.

2. Getting your franchise package ready for the Gulf

This is what partners will read before deciding whether to meet you. It needs to feel made for them – not translated from Korea.

2.1. The franchise document itself

A serious operator will want answers to these questions:

- How much does it cost to become your Master Franchise or Area Developer? (initial fee, ongoing royalty, marketing fund contribution)
- Which territory do they get, and for how long?
- How many stores do they have to open, by when?
- How much does it cost to open one store in their market – calculated using real Gulf rents and salaries, not Korean numbers?
- What's the realistic payback on a single store?

If your current document doesn't answer these in Gulf terms, we adapt it.

2.2. The brand and operating manual

Partners are buying a system, not just a logo. They'll want to see:

- The store playbook – kitchen setup, training, staffing
- The brand book, and how you'd allow Arabic versions of the menu, signage, and packaging
- Which dishes are mandatory across all stores, and where local flexibility is allowed
- How the cold-chain supply works, and whether your Korean factory can serve the Gulf directly or whether a regional kitchen will be needed eventually

2.3. The legal pieces

Each market needs the right contract structure:

- **UAE.**
The franchise agreement is governed by UAE commercial law. Registration with the Department of Economy is practice, not a legal requirement.
- **Saudi Arabia.**
The franchise must be registered with the Ministry of Investment under the Saudi Franchise Law of 2019. The disclosure document has to be filed at least 14 days before any agreement is signed.

We don't replace your lawyers. We coordinate with them and our local advisors so nothing is missed.

2.4. Adapting for the Gulf – the must-do list

- Halal certification plan, recipe by recipe
- Arabic adaptation of the brand – logo, menu, signage, packaging
- Menu calibration – sweetness, portion size, beverage strength. Small adjustments to suit Gulf tastes without breaking the Korean brand
- Confirm the cold-chain handover from your Korean shipping to local Gulf logistics

3. Knowing the market

Operators in the Gulf will not expect Dessert39 to have already done all the paperwork. But they will expect to see a confident, sequenced plan. Vagueness here loses deals. Our job is to make sure you walk in with the right answers.

3.1. The UAE Side

- **Trade license.**
From the Department of Economy in the emirate where the partner sets up.
- **Food safety.**
Handled through Dubai Municipality (for Dubai stores) or ADAFSA (for Abu Dhabi stores).
- **Halal certification.**
Done with an ESMA-recognized body. Recipes are reviewed one by one.
- **Retail-packaged products.**
If you sell SKUs through supermarkets, those products need ECAS or Emirates Quality Mark approval.
- **Franchise contract.**
There's no separate franchise law in the UAE. The contract itself governs the relationship.

3.2. The Saudi Side

- **Franchise registration.**
Must be filed with the Ministry of Investment under the 2019 Saudi Franchise Law. The disclosure document goes in at least 14 days before the contract is signed.
- **Trade license.**
The partner gets this through the relevant municipality – Riyadh, Jeddah, Dammam, etc.
- **Food safety.**
The Saudi Food and Drug Authority (SFDA) handles food import, factory registration, and retail.
- **Halal certification.**
Mandatory and audited. Done with an SFDA-recognized body.
- **Retail-packaged products.**
Need SASO / SABER conformity to be sold through supermarkets.

3.3. Why the Gulf consumer is your customer

- Diabetes is widespread – about 17% of adults in the UAE and 18% in Saudi Arabia. Few imported dessert brands address this honestly.
- Both governments are actively pushing wellness through national strategies – UAE Wellbeing 2031 and Saudi Vision 2030 Quality of Life Program.
- Korean lifestyle brands carry a strong halo, especially with people under 35.
- Nobody else has anchored "low-sugar dessert café" at scale in the region. The category is open for you to take.

4. Finding your partners

This is the heart of the engagement. Everything else supports this.

4.1. The kinds of partners we'd talk to

Partners come in four shapes. We'd talk to all four, and we'd screen them against the same criteria.

Big F&B holding groups.

Companies that already run several international restaurant or café brands. They have capital, real estate access, and operational depth. Best fit if you ever did want one partner for the whole Gulf.

Café and dessert specialists.

Operators who run 20-100 stores in one concept. They understand cafés deeply. Better fit for a single-market Area Developer role – typically the kind of partner Saudi Arabia rewards.

Retail and lifestyle groups.

Luxury retailers and mall developers with food and beverage arms. Strong if you want premium store locations and retail SKUs sold inside their existing stores.

Family offices and investment groups.

Passive capital, often paired with an operating partner. Useful when there's a smaller operator with the right talent but not enough money behind them.

4.2. What every partner has to pass

- Cold-chain experience. Your supply system runs at -40°C. The partner has to be able to handle this.
- Money to commit. The initial fee plus a multi-year build-out fund.
- Real estate access. They need to be able to secure good locations in good malls.
- Bandwidth. They can't already be running ten other concepts and stretched thin.
- Reputation. No serious legal or compliance issues – your brand has to be safe with them.

A track record with Asian or Korean concepts is a bonus, not a requirement.

4.3. How we move them through the funnel

Five steps. Your name stays confidential until step four.

Step 1 - Long list (50-80 names).

Every operator in the UAE and Saudi Arabia who could plausibly do this.

Step 2 - Shortlist (15-20 names).

The operators who pass the criteria above. From here we identify the strongest candidate per market – what we call the "anchor candidate."

Step 3 - First contact.

Carefully – by warm introduction or direct outreach – describing a "Korean premium dessert café concept" without naming Dessert39.

Step 4 - Confidentiality and disclosure.

We send an NDA to operators who respond seriously. Once signed, we share your name and the full franchise package. They start their internal review.

Step 5 - Meeting and MOU.

The strongest candidates get on calls with your team in Seoul. The strongest of those moves to a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU). After that, the contract drafting begins.

4.4. How we run the process - the rules we don't break

- We don't blast the market. The outreach is quiet, sequenced, partner by partner.
- Your name stays private until step four. We are protecting your brand value.
- We work two or three candidates in parallel per market – but no candidate knows about the others. That keeps the conversation honest from each one.
- Within the shortlist, we pick one anchor candidate per market – the one most likely to close – and we use them to set the terms others have to match.
- Every deal stays between you and the partner. We facilitate. You sign.

5. The four-month plan, week by week

What's happening, what we deliver, and what counts as "done."

Month 1 - Setting up (Weeks 1-4)

By the end of Month 1: your franchise package is being adapted, the regulatory plan for both markets is documented, and the first long list of potential partners is ready for outreach.

Week 1 - Kickoff

- We confirm whether to start with UAE, Saudi, or both
- We agree on partnership structure (one Gulf partner, or split)
- We set up a shared file folder for everything
- You give us your current franchise package and product information

Week 2 - Adapting the franchise package

- We review your existing pack against what Gulf operators expect
- We map out what's missing or needs to change
- We start the halal certification plan, recipe by recipe

Week 3 - Regulatory plan

- We document the UAE pathway (licenses, food safety, halal, packaged products)
- We document the Saudi pathway (Ministry of Investment filing, SFDA, halal, packaged products)
- We confirm timelines and the named authorities involved

Week 4 - Partner long list

- We build a list of 50-80 potential partners across UAE and Saudi
- We sort them by type – holding groups, specialists, retail/lifestyle, family offices
- We confirm the qualifying criteria with you

Month 2 - Reaching out (Weeks 5-8)

By the end of Month 2: we've made first contact with the strongest candidates and the first NDAs are being signed.

Week 5 - Outreach starts

- We approach the top tiers – holding groups and specialists
- Your name is not disclosed yet
- We track every reply

Week 6 - Confidentiality and first disclosure

- For partners who reply, we send NDAs
- Once signed, we share your name and the franchise package
- They start their internal review

Week 7 - Outreach widens

- We approach retail/lifestyle groups and family offices
- We refine the partner brief based on early feedback

Week 8 - Mid-funnel review

- We sit down with you (Seoul) to review who's progressing
- We schedule the first calls between your team and the strongest candidates

Month 3 - Narrowing down (Weeks 9-12)

By the end of Month 3: we have a real shortlist, your team has met the candidates, and the first MOU is being drafted.

Week 9 - Shortlist

- We confirm 4-6 strong candidates per market
- We name the anchor candidate per market – the strongest one

Week 10 - Calls with your team in Seoul

- Your team meets the shortlist candidates by call
- We capture every follow-up question and concern

Week 11 - UAE MOU drafting

- We start drafting the MOU with the UAE anchor candidate
- Terms covered: territory, exclusivity, store openings, fees

Week 12 - Saudi NDA round

- Saudi candidates progress to the NDA stage
- We frame the Vision 2030 wellness alignment for Saudi-specific conversations

Month 4 - Closing in (Weeks 13-16)

By the end of Month 4: your strongest candidate has met your team in person, the UAE MOU is final, and we've planned the next six months.

Week 13 - Face-to-face meetings

- Anchor candidates meet your team in person – Seoul or the Gulf
- This is where the relationship gets real

Week 14 - UAE MOU finalized

- Sign-ready UAE MOU
- Saudi candidates progress to calls with your team

Week 15 - Review

- We refresh the green/yellow/red status across all three areas
- We review the pipeline and any risks

Week 16 - Wrap-up and the next six months

- We deliver a summary of what's changed since Week 1
- We propose the plan for the next six months – from MOU to signed Master Franchise Agreement, and on to first stores

6. How you'll know it's working

No consulting jargon. Real signs of progress.

On your franchise package

- Has the Gulf-adapted version been approved?
- Has the halal certification plan been signed off?
- Has the Arabic identity been delivered?

On your regulatory plan

- Is the UAE pathway documented end-to-end?
- Is the Saudi pathway documented end-to-end?
- Do we know which authorities matter and what their timelines look like?

On the partner pipeline

- How many partners are on the long list?
- How many are on the qualified shortlist?
- How many have signed NDAs?
- How many have met your team?
- How many MOUs are being drafted?
- How many face-to-face meetings have happened?

How often we update you

- Every week – outreach update and pipeline movement
- Every two weeks – who's progressing, who's stuck
- Every month – a refreshed status of everything, with the green/yellow/red view
- End of Month 4 – a full summary and the next six-month plan

Next step

If this plan looks right to you, the next step is a 30-minute call between your team in Seoul and ours in Sharjah. We'd walk through the questions in section 1.7, agree on a starting territory and structure, and confirm the engagement scope and commercial terms.

Sharjah is five hours behind Seoul – we'll find a time that works for your calendar.

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